South Africa's participation at the 56th World Economic Forum (WEF)

Mpho Parks Tau

21 January 2026

South Africa understands the transformative power of dialogue. From overcoming a legacy of division through constructive engagement to securing key commitments during the G20 Summit in Johannesburg last year, the nation has repeatedly shown that conversation, consensus, and collective action can turn challenges into opportunities.

The country will bring the same spirit to the global stage at the 56th World Economic Forum (WEF) taking place in Davos-Klosters from 19 to 23 January 2026. Through our participation, we aim to foster practical solutions for stability and shared growth in a global arena that is marked by sharpening geopolitical rivalry and rapid technological disruption.

Convened under the theme "A Spirit of Dialogue," WEF 2026 offers a unique platform for leaders from government, business, civil society, science, and culture from participating countries to move beyond immediate global crisis management and engage in strategic, forward-looking reflection.

South Africa strongly aligns with this theme, recognising that a renewed global spirit of dialogue is essential for navigating an increasingly polarised world. We firmly believe that multilateralism remains the most effective mechanism for tackling complex challenges that transcend national borders. But we are focused on putting words into action. South Africa is focusing on active implementation over the medium term and will utilise the WEF platform as a way of concretising this spirit.

South Africa's participation will build on its demonstrated leadership in fostering international cooperation, notably through its successful hosting of the G20 Summit. During our G20 Presidency, South Africa led an inclusive engagement and championed African-led approaches to global issues, securing vital commitments on debt sustainability, climate finance, critical minerals, and inclusive growth.

Building on what has been achieved, WEF 2026 provides South Africa with a vital platform to elevate the priorities of developing economies and amplify the voice of the Global South amid evolving global alliances. Through constructive engagement with partners across all regions, South Africa advocates for balanced outcomes that reflect diverse perspectives and shared responsibility. We will be bringing the message of South Africa, and indeed Africa's, reindustrialisation as an apex priority. Our continent requires bold and decisive action to alleviate poverty, reduce unemployment and erase inequality.

Our delegation to WEF 2026 will be high-level, underscoring the government's commitment to coordinated economic diplomacy. Members will engage in thematic discussions ranging from industrial development and energy security to innovation, education, and international relations.

A core objective of South Africa's presence is to position the country as a credible, stable, and attractive investment destination. The forum offers direct access to global business leaders and investors, enabling South Africa to showcase its reform momentum, investment opportunities, and long-term growth potential.

South Africa's economy is anchored by a stable macroeconomic framework, deep and sophisticated financial markets, a robust legal system, and advanced digital and telecommunications infrastructure. As the most diversified economy on the African continent, it continues to serve as a critical gateway to regional and global markets.

Under the leadership of President Cyril Ramaphosa, government has pursued a comprehensive programme of structural reforms to strengthen governance, improve the business environment, and unlock new growth engines. Notable progress has been achieved in addressing longstanding constraints in key sectors such as energy, freight rail, and ports through coordinated efforts led by Operation Vulindlela.

Reforms in the electricity sector are modernising the market, diversifying the energy mix, and enhancing long-term energy security. South Africa remains committed to a just and sustainable energy transition aligned with global climate objectives and supported by appropriate international climate finance. This approach balances environmental responsibility with economic inclusion and social protection.

In parallel, government is implementing a clear roadmap to revitalise the transport and logistics sector. Improvements in freight rail and port efficiency are vital to reducing costs of doing business, boosting competitiveness, and supporting export-led growth. These reforms are essential for restoring investor confidence and strengthening South Africa's integration into global value chains.

South Africa is also actively positioning itself within emerging technological and innovation pathways. The country supports the responsible deployment of frontier technologies including artificial intelligence, biotechnology, quantum computing, and new energy solutions while advocating for strong, ethical, and inclusive frameworks.

Beyond economics and technology, South Africa's constitutional democracy remains rooted in the values of human dignity, equality, non-racialism, non-sexism, the rule of law, and accountable governance.

This is carried to the global stage, where our country consistently advocates for a peaceful, just, and equitable international order. Our foreign policy prioritises dialogue, the peaceful resolution of conflicts, and respect for international law as foundations for sustainable global development.

Our participation in the World Economic Forum 2026 is both strategic and principled. It advances national development objectives while contributing to a renewed global spirit of dialogue, partnership, and solidarity. Through inclusive engagement and multilateral cooperation, South Africa seeks to help shape a more resilient, stable, and prosperous future for all.

Mpho Parks Tau, Minister of Trade, Industry and Competition

#GovZAUpdates

img

Share this page

Facebook Twitter WhatsApp

www.gov.za is a product of
Government Communications

Explore

Statements
Documents
Events
Government opinion pieces
About South Africa
About government

Services for residents
Services for organisations
Services for foreign nationals
Sitemap
Get e-mail updates
FAQs

Contact your government
Feedback
RSS feeds
Terms and conditions
Android mobile app
Apple mobile app

Copyright © 2026 Government of South Africa